

Northwind Robotics

Employee Handbook

Edition 2026.1 · Effective 1 April 2026

Prepared by the People Operations Team, Bengaluru

This handbook is an internal reference document. It describes the policies, benefits and working practices that apply to all permanent employees of Northwind Robotics Private Limited. It is intended as a practical guide rather than a legal contract. Where a written employment agreement differs from this handbook, the employment agreement takes precedence.

1. About Northwind Robotics

Northwind Robotics Private Limited was founded in 2014 in Bengaluru, India, by Dr. Anita Raghavan and Marcus Lindqvist. The company began as a four-person research group working on autonomous material-handling equipment for warehouses. It now employs just over 700 people across four offices: Bengaluru (headquarters), Pune, Rotterdam and Austin, Texas.

The company designs and manufactures autonomous mobile robots, known internally as AMRs, for warehouse and light-manufacturing environments. The flagship product line is the Kestrel series, a family of floor robots that transport shelving units and pallets inside distribution centres without fixed rails or guide wires. A second product line, Harrier, provides the fleet management software that coordinates the robots.

1.1 Mission statement

Our mission is to remove repetitive physical strain from warehouse work while increasing throughput for our customers. We believe automation should make jobs safer and more interesting, not simply cheaper. Every product decision at Northwind Robotics is measured against three questions: does it reduce injury risk, does it reduce wasted movement, and can a non-engineer operate it after one day of training?

1.2 Company values

Evidence over opinion. Design arguments are settled with measurements from the test floor, not with seniority. Any employee may request bench time to test a claim.

Small reversible steps. We prefer shipping a narrow feature that can be rolled back over a large release that cannot. This applies to firmware, software and process changes alike.

Write it down. Decisions that affect more than one team are recorded in a written decision note stored in the company wiki. A decision that exists only in a meeting is treated as not yet made.

Respect the floor. Engineers are expected to spend at least two days per quarter at a customer site observing real operators using our equipment.

1.3 Legal entity and registration

Northwind Robotics Private Limited is registered in Karnataka, India, with corporate identity number U29309KA2014PTC077412. The registered office address is 4th Floor, Ashwin Tech Park, Outer Ring Road, Mahadevapura, Bengaluru 560048. The European subsidiary, Northwind Robotics Europe B.V., is registered in Rotterdam, Netherlands.

2. Working Hours and Attendance

Northwind Robotics operates on a flexible core-hours model. Employees are expected to be available and reachable between 11:00 and 16:00 in their local office time zone. Outside those core hours, employees may arrange their working day as they prefer, provided their commitments to their team are met.

The standard working week is 40 hours, normally spread across Monday to Friday. Employees are not expected to work on Saturdays or Sundays. Where weekend work is unavoidable, for example during a customer go-live, the employee is entitled to compensatory time off which must be taken within 30 days.

2.1 Attendance recording

Attendance is recorded through the Harrier People portal. Employees are not required to clock in and out. Instead, the portal records planned absences, leave and on-site customer visits. Managers review attendance records once per month.

2.2 Overtime

Northwind Robotics does not operate a paid overtime scheme for salaried staff. Sustained overtime is treated as a planning failure rather than an achievement. If an employee works more than 45 hours in a week for three consecutive weeks, their manager is required to raise a workload review with the department head.

Hourly-paid manufacturing technicians in the Pune facility are covered by a separate overtime agreement which pays 1.5 times the base hourly rate for hours worked beyond 40 hours in a week, and 2 times the base hourly rate for hours worked on public holidays.

3. Leave and Time Off

The leave year runs from 1 January to 31 December. Leave entitlements are credited at the start of the leave year and are pro-rated for employees who join partway through the year.

3.1 Annual leave

All permanent employees receive 24 days of paid annual leave per year. Employees who have completed five continuous years of service receive an additional 3 days, bringing their entitlement to 27 days. A maximum of 10 unused annual leave days may be carried forward into the following leave year. Days beyond that limit lapse on 31 December and are not paid out.

Annual leave should be requested at least two weeks in advance through the Harrier People portal. Requests of five consecutive days or more require approval from the department head in addition to the direct manager.

3.2 Sick leave

Employees receive 12 days of paid sick leave per leave year. A medical certificate is required for any absence of more than three consecutive working days. Unused sick leave does not carry forward and is not paid out on exit.

3.3 Parental leave

Primary caregivers receive 26 weeks of fully paid parental leave. Secondary caregivers receive 8 weeks of fully paid leave, which may be taken in up to three separate blocks within the first 12 months after birth or adoption. Both entitlements apply equally to birth, adoption and surrogacy, and there is no minimum service requirement.

Employees returning from parental leave of more than 12 weeks may work at 80 percent of full hours for their first two months back, at full pay.

3.4 Bereavement and emergency leave

Five days of paid bereavement leave are available on the death of an immediate family member, and two days for extended family. In addition, every employee has three days of discretionary emergency leave per year which may be used without giving a reason, subject only to informing the manager.

3.5 Public holidays

Office	Public holidays per year	Floating holidays
Bengaluru	11	2
Pune	11	2
Rotterdam	9	2
Austin	10	2

Floating holidays may be used for any religious or cultural observance not covered by the office public holiday list.

4. Remote and Hybrid Working

Northwind Robotics operates a hybrid working model. Employees in software, design and corporate functions are expected in the office three days per week. Hardware, test and manufacturing roles require four or five days on site because the work depends on physical access to robots and test rigs.

Teams choose their own anchor days, but each team must publish its anchor days in the wiki so that cross-team meetings can be scheduled predictably. Tuesday and Wednesday are the most common anchor days across the company.

4.1 Working from another country

Employees may work from another country for up to 30 calendar days per leave year without a formal transfer, provided they have written approval from their manager and from People Operations. Stays longer than 30 days create tax and permanent-establishment risk for the company and require a formal secondment agreement.

4.2 Home office allowance

Each employee receives a one-time home office allowance of 45,000 rupees in India, or the local equivalent of approximately 500 euros in Europe and 550 US dollars in the United States. The allowance may be spent on a desk, chair, monitor, keyboard, lighting or acoustic treatment. Receipts must be submitted within 60 days of purchase. Equipment purchased with the allowance belongs to the employee, not to the company.

A refresh of 15,000 rupees, or the local equivalent, becomes available every three years.

4.3 Internet reimbursement

Employees working in a hybrid or fully remote arrangement may claim up to 1,500 rupees per month, or the local equivalent, towards home broadband costs. The claim is made once per quarter through the expense system and does not require individual receipts.

5. Expenses and Business Travel

All business expenses are submitted through the Harrier Expense module. Claims must be submitted within 45 days of the expense being incurred. Claims older than 90 days are not reimbursed except in exceptional circumstances approved by the finance director.

5.1 Approval thresholds

Expenses below 5,000 rupees, or the local equivalent, are approved automatically by the direct manager. Expenses between 5,000 and 50,000 rupees require department head approval. Anything above 50,000 rupees requires finance director approval before the expense is incurred, not afterwards.

5.2 Travel class

Flights of less than six hours are booked in economy class. Flights of six hours or more may be booked in premium economy. Business class is approved only for flights longer than nine hours, and only for employees at director level and above, or where a medical accommodation applies.

Rail travel within Europe is preferred over flying where the total journey time is under five hours. Northwind Robotics counts avoided flights towards its published carbon reduction target.

5.3 Accommodation and daily allowance

Hotel booking limits are 6,000 rupees per night in Indian cities, 180 euros per night in Europe, and 220 US dollars per night in the United States. Where a conference hotel exceeds these limits, the higher rate may be approved in advance.

Employees travelling on company business receive a daily meal allowance of 1,200 rupees in India, 55 euros in Europe and 65 US dollars in the United States. No receipts are required for the meal allowance. Alcohol is not reimbursable except at approved client entertainment events.

5.4 Personal vehicle use

Employees using a personal vehicle for business travel are reimbursed at 14 rupees per kilometre in India and 0.23 euros per kilometre in Europe. Parking and tolls are reimbursed separately against receipts. Fuel receipts are not accepted where the per-kilometre rate is claimed.

6. Equipment and Information Security

Every employee is issued a company laptop. Software engineers may choose between a 16-inch MacBook Pro and a Lenovo ThinkPad P-series running Ubuntu. Hardware and firmware engineers are issued a ThinkPad because the robot toolchain requires Linux and direct USB access to controller boards.

Laptops are refreshed every three years. The old device is either returned to IT or purchased by the employee at its depreciated book value, which after three years is typically around 15 percent of the original purchase price.

6.1 Access control

All company systems are accessed through single sign-on. Multi-factor authentication using a hardware security key is mandatory for engineering, finance and People Operations staff. SMS-based one-time passwords are not accepted as a second factor anywhere in the company.

Passwords must be at least 14 characters. The company password manager is provided to all employees, including for personal use, because reused personal passwords are a common route into corporate accounts.

6.2 Data classification

Information is classified at four levels. **Public** material may be shared freely. **Internal** material may be shared with any employee but not outside the company. **Confidential** material, which includes customer site layouts, unreleased firmware and salary data, is shared only with named individuals. **Restricted** material, which covers safety incident investigations and unpatched security vulnerabilities, is limited to an explicit access list maintained by the security team.

6.3 Reporting a security incident

Suspected security incidents must be reported within one hour of discovery to the security team through the dedicated incident channel. Employees who report an incident in good faith are never penalised, including when the employee caused the incident themselves. The company treats concealment as the serious offence, not the mistake.

6.4 Use of artificial intelligence tools

Approved AI coding assistants may be used for company work. Confidential or Restricted material must not be pasted into any external AI service that has not been reviewed by the security team. A list of reviewed and approved services is maintained in the wiki. Generated code is subject to the same review standards as hand-written code, and the committing engineer remains accountable for it.

7. Performance, Promotion and Pay

Northwind Robotics runs two formal performance cycles per year, concluding in March and September. The cycle is based on written self-assessment, manager assessment and peer feedback from three to five colleagues chosen jointly by the employee and manager.

7.1 Rating scale

The company deliberately uses a three-point scale rather than a five-point scale, to avoid false precision. The ratings are **Developing**, **Performing** and **Exceeding**. There is no forced distribution and no quota for any rating.

7.2 Promotion

Promotions are decided in a calibration meeting held after each cycle, attended by all managers in a department plus one manager from an unrelated department who acts as a neutral observer. Promotion requires evidence of sustained performance at the next level for at least two quarters, not a single strong project.

7.3 Salary review

Salary is reviewed once per year, in the March cycle. Adjustments take effect from 1 May. A market benchmarking exercise is carried out every year using two external compensation data providers, and the company targets the 65th percentile of the market for each role and location.

7.4 Bonus

All permanent employees participate in a single company-wide bonus pool. The pool is funded against annual revenue and gross margin targets. The target bonus is 10 percent of base salary for individual contributors and 15 percent for managers and above. There is no individual performance multiplier applied to the bonus, because the company found that individual multipliers discouraged people from helping other teams.

8. Learning and Development

Each employee has an annual learning budget of 80,000 rupees, or the local equivalent of roughly 900 euros or 1,000 US dollars. The budget may be spent on conferences, online courses, books, certifications, professional memberships and language tuition. It cannot be carried into the next year.

In addition to the budget, every employee has 10 working days per year designated as learning days. These days are not annual leave and do not need to produce a deliverable. They do need to be booked in the calendar in advance so the team can plan around them.

8.1 Conference attendance

Employees may attend one international conference per year funded separately from the learning budget, provided they present an internal summary session within one month of returning. Speaking at a conference is funded without limit and counts as working time, not as learning days.

8.2 Internal mobility

Employees who have been in a role for at least 12 months may apply for internal openings without informing their current manager in advance. Managers are not permitted to block an internal transfer, though a handover period of up to 60 days may be negotiated.

8.3 Mentoring

The mentoring programme runs in six-month cohorts starting in February and August. Mentors and mentees are matched across departments rather than within a team, so that the relationship does not overlap with the reporting line.

9. Workplace Conduct

Northwind Robotics expects every employee to treat colleagues, customers and suppliers with respect. Harassment, discrimination and retaliation are grounds for dismissal.

9.1 Raising a concern

Concerns may be raised with a direct manager, with any member of People Operations, or through the independent external reporting line operated by a third-party provider, which accepts anonymous reports in English, Hindi, Kannada, Marathi and Dutch. All reports are acknowledged within two working days.

9.2 Conflicts of interest

Employees must declare any financial interest in a supplier, customer or competitor of Northwind Robotics. Outside employment is permitted provided it does not compete with the company, does not use company equipment or time, and is declared in writing. Advisory roles at early-stage companies are generally approved.

9.3 Gifts

Gifts from suppliers with a value above 2,000 rupees, or the local equivalent, must be declared. Cash and cash equivalents such as gift cards may never be accepted regardless of value. Modest hospitality such as a working lunch does not need to be declared.

9.4 Safety on the test floor

Anyone entering a robot test area must complete the floor safety induction, which takes about 90 minutes and is repeated annually. Closed-toe shoes and a high-visibility vest are mandatory in the test area. Any person on the floor may press an emergency stop at any time for any reason, and no explanation is required afterwards.

10. Joining and Leaving

10.1 Probation

New employees serve a probation period of six months. Probation may be shortened by the department head, and may be extended once by a maximum of three months where a specific, written improvement plan is in place.

10.2 Onboarding

Every new joiner is assigned an onboarding buddy from a different team. The first week includes the floor safety induction, a security briefing, and a half-day visit to a live customer site wherever one is within travelling distance. New engineers are expected to ship a small change to production within their first two weeks; the onboarding buddy is responsible for finding a suitable first task.

10.3 Notice periods

The notice period is 30 days during probation and 60 days after probation has been completed. For director-level roles and above, the notice period is 90 days. Notice may be shortened by mutual agreement, and the company may choose to pay in lieu of notice.

10.4 Exit process

Departing employees complete an exit conversation with People Operations, which is separate from any conversation with their manager. Exit themes are summarised anonymously and reported to the leadership team every quarter. Company equipment must be returned on or before the final working day, except where the employee has purchased the device at book value.

10.5 Rehiring

Former employees who left in good standing are welcome to reapply. Employees who return within 24 months retain their previous service length for the purpose of calculating annual leave entitlement and long-service benefits.

11. Glossary of Internal Terms

Term	Meaning
AMR	Autonomous mobile robot. The category of product Northwind Robotics builds.
Anchor day	A day on which a whole team is expected to be in the office together.
Book value	The depreciated value of a company asset, used when an employee buys their old laptop.
Calibration	The meeting where managers compare performance ratings across a department.
Decision note	A short written record of a cross-team decision, stored in the wiki.
Floor	The robot test and manufacturing area.
Harrier	The fleet management software product, and also the internal portal suite built on it.
Kestrel	The flagship family of warehouse floor robots.
Learning day	One of ten annual days set aside for study rather than delivery.
Restricted	The highest data classification level, limited to an explicit access list.

12. Document Control

This handbook is reviewed annually by People Operations and approved by the leadership team. Material changes are announced at the monthly all-hands meeting and summarised in a change log at the top of the wiki page. Questions about the interpretation of any policy in this document should be directed to People Operations. This edition supersedes all previous editions.

Document owner: Head of People Operations. Next scheduled review: March 2027.